Module 1
Learn With PsycLearn Essentials

Module 2
Opening to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 3
Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 4
Biological Contributing Factors

Lesson 5: Genetic Contributing Factors

- Developmental Psychopathology
  Reading • 3 min
- Genetic Contributing Factors
  Reading • 3 min
- The Link Between Genes and Psychopathology
  Video • 4 min
- Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- Genetic Contributing Factors for Depression
  Reading • 10 min
- Epigenetic Contributors to Depression
  Video • 3 min
- Genetic Contributing Factors for Bipolar Disorder
  Reading • 3 min
- Check Your Understanding: Genetic Contributing Factors
  Practice Assignment • 4 min

Lesson 6: Neurobiological Contributing Factors

- Depressive Disorders: A Case Study
  Reading • 5 min
- Communication in the Synapse
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- Neurochemical Contributors to Depression
  Reading • 10 min
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- **Hormonal Contributors to Depression**
  Reading • 5 min
- Brain Regions Linked to Depression
  Video • 4 min
- Neurobiological Contributors to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 15 min
- Check Your Understanding: Biological Contributing Factors
  Practice Assignment • 6 min

Key Takeaways

- Key Takeaways: Biological Contributing Factors
  Reading • 10 min

Module 4 Quiz

- Module Quiz: Biological Contributing Factors
  Graded Assignment • 9 min

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Psychological Contributing Factors

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Treatments for Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

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Hormonal Contributors to Depression

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Hormonal Factors

Hormones are chemical messengers used by the body to communicate messages from one location to another. Research suggests that the sex hormones—estrogen, progesterone, and the androgens (which include testosterone)—play a role in increasing the risk for depression (Slavich & Sacher, 2019). This seems to be particularly true among women, which may account for the consistent gender differences in depression rates, and explain why there is a correlation between hormonal changes and depression across the lifespan (Kundakovic & Rocks, 2022).

The link between hormonal activity and depression can be seen in rates of depression in girls before and after puberty (Slavich & Sacher, 2019). Before puberty, rates of depression are similar between boys and girls, and relatively low, around 3%. After puberty, however, depression rates are higher for both men and women, but women are more than twice as likely as men to develop depression. Though the exact mechanism by which women are much more likely than men to develop depression is not well understood, the global prevalence ratios suggest that differences may be due to biological factors and sex hormone fluctuations (Albert, 2015; Kundakovic & Rocks, 2022) rather than differences in race, education, culture, or other sociocultural factors (Rai et al., 2013).

The majority of hormones that impact psychological health, including depression, are tied to stress. When a person is under stress, the body mobilizes to initiate a stress response, triggering a multi-step chain of events that ultimately leads to the release of adrenaline and the stress hormone cortisol. **Adrenaline,** also called epinephrine, is a hormone that is secreted in large amounts in response to fear, anxiety, or stress. **Cortisol** is a hormone that improves the body's ability to manage stress and to repair itself. However, exposure to prolonged or chronic stress can lead to excessive levels of cortisol, which can have harmful effects on the body. The experience of chronic stress and chronically elevated levels of cortisol are associated with increased risk for depression (Adam et al., 2010; Stetler & Miller, 2011; Zunszain et al., 2011).

Psychologist Joelle LeMoult and colleagues investigated the similarity in mother-daughter cortisol levels (LeMoult et al., 2015). If depressed mothers and their daughters had cortisol levels that were more similar than those of nondepressed mothers and their daughters, the researchers hypothesized that cortisol could be one mechanism by which depression is transmitted from parent to child (Adam et al., 2010). However, it is undetermined whether this link is genetic (Bartels, et al., 2003) or environmental (Papp et al., 2013), but it could possibly be both. LeMoult and colleagues (2015) studied cortisol levels in girls between the ages of 9 and 15, who had never been diagnosed with depression, and their mothers. Half of the girls had a mother who had never been diagnosed with depression and half of the girls had a mother who had been diagnosed with a severe depressive disorder but was currently symptom-free. LeMoult and her colleagues found that cortisol levels of all of the mother-daughter pairs were very similar. Daughters and mothers who were diagnosed with depression had levels of cortisol that were consistently higher than did daughters and mothers who never had depression. The significant difference between daughters with a depressed mother and daughters whose mothers were not depressed suggest that elevated cortisol levels may be one mechanism by which depression is transmitted from mother to daughter (LeMoult et al., 2015).

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